

EVIDENCE REVIEW · INDEPENDENT ANALYSIS

What Actually Wins the Presidential Hackathon?

Every International-Track Team of Excellence, 2019-2025:
project merit, national timing, and what happened afterward

A fact-checked study of 14 winning entries

Method: primary press releases, official records, project traces

Prepared for the Pred-hack project · July 2026

All claims cited; absences of evidence reported as such

This review corrects two claims found in this project's own earlier research files. It observes winners only — losing entries are invisible — so causal conclusions are stated with that limit in mind.

Contents

1	The Question and the Method	2
2	The Case Files, 2019-2025	2
2.1	What the winners were, in their year’s context	2
3	Findings	4
3.1	Finding 1: winners’ domains move in lockstep with the year’s theme	4
3.2	Finding 2: half the winners did not start at the hackathon	4
3.3	Finding 3: the afterlife record is split exactly in half	5
3.4	Finding 4: the diplomatic pattern is visible and unhidden	5
3.5	Finding 5: corrections to our own earlier files	6
4	Verdict: Good Project, or National Need?	6
4.1	What this means for the CarbonPass entry	7
5	Limitations	7
	References	8

1 The Question and the Method

The question under test: *when a team wins the Presidential Hackathon’s International Track, is it because the project is genuinely excellent — or because it lands on the nation’s immediate need at the right moment?* The question matters because our own entry strategy depends on the answer.

Method. We identified the publicly named Teams of Excellence for each International Track edition, 2019–2025 (two per year in official reporting; 14 in total), then researched each against three factual axes: (1) what the project actually was and how technically substantial it was *at the time of winning*; (2) whether it pre-existed the competition; (3) whether any public trace of activity exists *after* the competition (websites, code repositories, partnerships, press, return appearances). Sources are official press releases (MODA, Office of the President), the competition’s own history pages, the winning organizations’ own publications, and third-party records (Open Contracting Partnership, CoST International, GitHub). Where we found nothing, we say “no public trace found” — which is evidence of absence only in the weak sense, and is labeled accordingly.

Two bias controls. First, this review deliberately re-verified claims made in this project’s own earlier research files, and corrects two of them (Section 3.5). Second, we observe winners only: the losing pool is invisible, so we cannot prove that better projects lost. Claims below are therefore about *what winners have in common*, not about what judges rejected.

The scoring frame the judges use. The rubric weights Feasibility 40%, Innovation 30%, Social Impact 30% at preliminaries; finals add Implementation & Verification at 30%¹. Note what this arithmetic already implies: “uniqueness of technology” is at most three-tenths of the decision; the other seven-tenths reward a solvable, important, demonstrable problem. The theme itself is set annually to the presidential agenda — 2026’s theme “echoes President Lai’s New Year vision”¹ — and the award is presented personally by the President in a ceremony attended by diplomatic representatives¹⁴. The institutional design, in other words, is not neutral between our two hypotheses. What follows tests whether the record matches the design.

2 The Case Files, 2019–2025

Table 1 compresses the fourteen case files; the paragraphs after it add what a table cannot.

2.1 What the winners were, in their year’s context

2019–2020: the transparency years. The theme was sustainable infrastructure; the global civic-tech zeitgeist was open contracting. Both years’ winners were procurement-data tools. Neither was algorithmically novel — SISOCS is a disclosure database; HPPI is an index over tender data — but both were *real*: SISOCS had been disclosing actual road projects since 2015 under a World Bank program², and Fiscal Force was built by an established data-for-governance organization⁵. The technically interesting entrant of 2019, Cartelogy’s red-flag cartel detection, is the one whose trail goes cold afterward.

2021–2022: the net-zero years. Themes pivoted to climate action. A/B Street won: a genuinely impressive piece of software — but one started in 2018, three years mature, with an existing community⁶. Its post-win account is the most instructive in the whole record: the creator nearly shut it down within a year of winning, and the project survived by institutional adoption (Turing Institute) unrelated to Taiwan⁷. The 2022 winners (field

Table 1: Fourteen Teams of Excellence: what they were, whether they pre-existed, what remains

Yr	Team	Origin	Project (verified description)	Pre-existence / afterlife
19	CoST Honduras	Honduras	SISOCS infrastructure-disclosure platform; disclosure rates 27%→95% ²	Pre-existed (2014-15, World Bank context); still operating, 1,850+ projects, ~US\$1bn disclosed ²
19	Cartelogy	Malaysia	Procurement red-flag tool; ~7,000 contracts converted to OCDS ³	Backed by civic-tech group; no public post-2019 trace found
20	Fiscal Force	India	Health Procurement Performance Index on Himachal Pradesh tenders ⁴	Built by CivicDataLab (existing org); grew into a formal CivicDataLab-OCF partnership with state governments ⁵
20	Learning Man	Taiwan	Social-housing procurement mapping via OC4IDS ⁴	No public post-2020 trace found
21	A/B Street	Intl. (US)	Open-source traffic simulation / street re-design tool ⁶	Pre-existed (2018); post-win: creator “almost ended the project,” continued at the Alan Turing Institute, now a one-person consultancy; development narrowed to a library ^{6,7}
21	Office Farmers	Intl.	Open-data crop adaptation modeling ⁸	No public post-2021 trace found
22	BRSDM@Er-Lin	Taiwan	Field biochar-pyrolysis equipment + cloud data platform, promoted toward Southeast Asia ⁹	Research-team project; no public post-2022 trace found
22	B.E.N.Z.	India	GIS-based urban-forest and tree-placement optimization ⁹	No public post-2022 trace found
23	HysonTech	Taiwan/India	“FarmABetterFish” AIoT aquaculture system ¹⁰	Hyson Technology sells intelligent-aquaculture products commercially today ¹¹
23	Re-Fill City	Thailand	App incentivizing bottle refill/reuse with retailer partnerships ¹⁰	No public post-2023 trace found
24	GreenhopeBCTW	Taiwan/US	Blockchain personal carbon wallet; monetizes verified behavior ¹²	GreenHope operates as a Web3 company today ¹³
24	MooApps	Indonesia	Digital livestock-monitoring app ¹²	No public post-2024 trace found
25	CropNow	India	NEST IoT device + CropDesk advisory: soil, microclimate, disease prediction ¹⁴	Invited back to the 2026 launch to present implementation progress ¹⁶
25	Beyond Hearing	Taiwan/France	AI+AR real-time sound-to-visual translation for the hearing-impaired ¹⁵	Invited back to the 2026 launch to present implementation progress ¹⁶

biochar pyrolysis; GIS tree placement) were competent applied projects squarely on the “practicing net zero” theme⁹; neither left a public trace we could find.

2023-2025: the AI-for-the-vulnerable years. As generative AI exploded, winning entries became AIoT systems with named beneficiary populations: fish farmers (HysonTech — an operating company whose product line exists today¹¹), consumers (Re-Fill City), individual citizens’ carbon behavior (GreenhopeBCTW — likewise an operating company¹³), smallholder farmers (CropNow), and the hearing-impaired (Beyond Hearing). The 2025 pair — an Indian agri-IoT startup-style team and a Taiwan-France accessibility team — were selected from nine finalists and honored by the President alongside India’s representative office chief¹⁴.

3 Findings

3.1 Finding 1: winners’ domains move in lockstep with the year’s theme

Figure 1 plots each examined winner’s domain against its year. The fit is essentially perfect: procurement tools win in procurement-themed years, carbon tools in net-zero years, AI-for-excluded-groups in the AI era. This is not necessarily judges “choosing politics over quality” — entrants self-select onto the theme, and the theme filters the pool before judges see it. But it means *no observed winner has ever won against the year’s current*. The theme is set to the presidential agenda by design¹; the record confirms the design works.

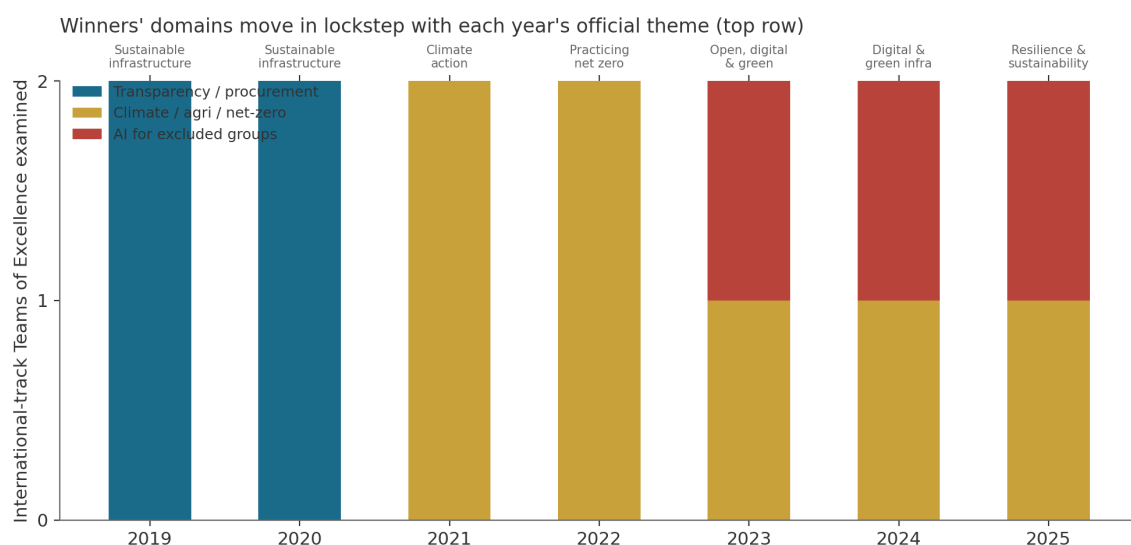


Figure 1: Domains of the 14 examined Teams of Excellence against each year’s official theme (top row). Sources: official press releases and history pages^{4,9,10,12,15}.

3.2 Finding 2: half the winners did not start at the hackathon

Of the fourteen examined entries, four were demonstrably pre-existing products or platforms (SISOCS, 2014–15²; A/B Street, 2018⁶; HysonTech’s aquaculture line¹¹; GreenHope’s carbon wallet¹³), and at least three more were new builds by existing organizations (CivicDataLab’s Fiscal Force⁵; Sinar-backed Cartelogy³; CropNow’s NEST device team¹⁴). For the remaining seven we found no evidence either way (Figure 2). The competition’s own rules acknowledge this reality: entries previously sold or awarded must be modified by at least 50%¹ — a rule you only write when mature entries are common. **Implication:**

“hackathon” is a misnomer; this is a showcase for projects that already exist at least in embryo, judged partly on how real they already are. That is consistent with a rubric that puts Feasibility (40%) above Innovation (30%)¹.

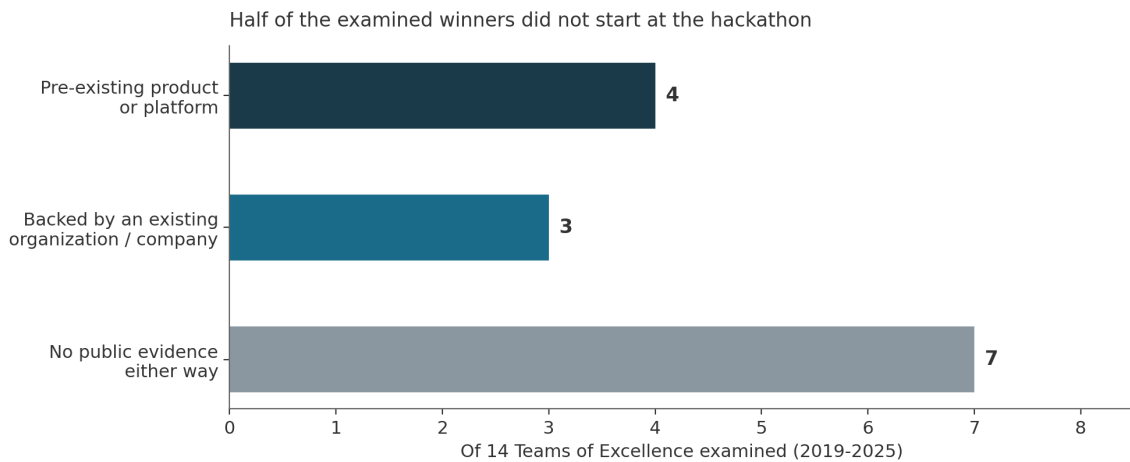


Figure 2: Maturity of the examined winners at the time of winning. “No public evidence either way” means our searches found neither a pre-existing product nor proof the build began at the competition.

3.3 Finding 3: the afterlife record is split exactly in half

Seven of fourteen winners show documented post-competition activity: CoST’s platform still discloses projects at national scale²; CivicDataLab’s hackathon index became a formal multi-state partnership⁵; A/B Street continues, diminished, through its creator’s consultancy⁷; HysonTech and GreenHope operate commercially^{11,13}; CropNow and Beyond Hearing were presented by MODA itself in 2026 as progressing implementations¹⁶. The other seven — Cartelogy, Learning Man, Office Farmers, BRSDM@Er-Lin, B.E.N.Z., Re-Fill City, MooApps — left no public trace we could find (Figure 3). The pattern within the split is sharper than the split itself: **every winner with a documented afterlife had an institution, company, or funded program behind it; every winner without one was, as far as the record shows, a team formed around a competition.** The Presidential Hackathon amplifies projects; the evidence does not show it sustaining them. (MODA’s own claim that winning proposals are implemented and tracked^{16,17} is documented mainly through domestic-track examples, such as the emergency-response system that became policy¹⁷.)

3.4 Finding 4: the diplomatic pattern is visible and unhidden

India appears among the winners in four of seven editions (Fiscal Force 2020, B.E.N.Z. 2022, HysonTech’s co-team 2023, CropNow 2025); the 2025 award ceremony was attended by the India-Taipei Association’s acting chairperson¹⁴; 2019’s winner came from Honduras, then a diplomatic ally, via a program co-branded with the World Bank². The International Track is, openly, an instrument of Taiwan’s “Taiwan Can Help” outreach — multinational teams are a scored expectation (at least one non-ROC national is mandatory¹). This does not diminish the winners; it describes the selection environment honestly: **a good project that also serves Taiwan’s international positioning is worth more, in this arena, than a slightly better project that does not.**

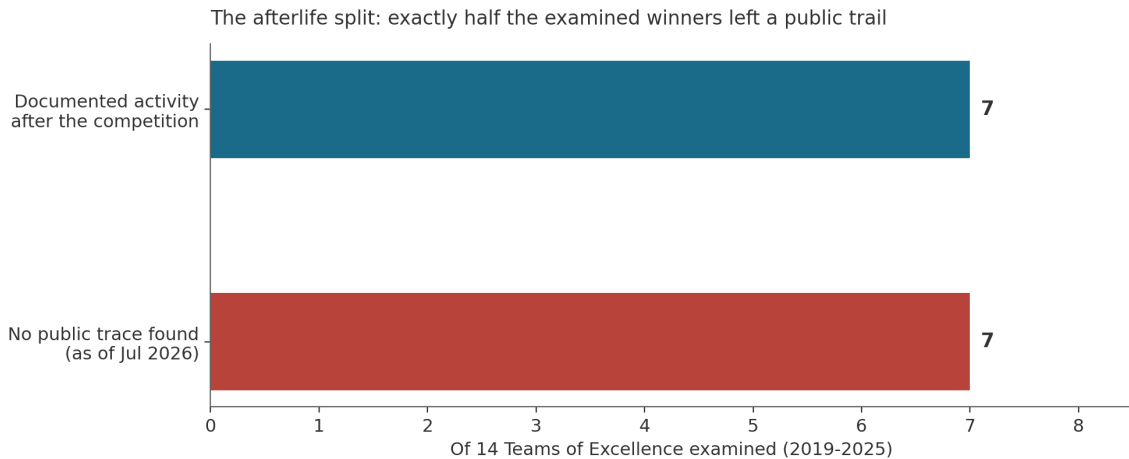


Figure 3: Post-competition public traces of the examined winners, as of July 2026. “No public trace found” is weak evidence — teams may continue privately — and is reported as such.

3.5 Finding 5: corrections to our own earlier files

Re-verification caught two errors in this project’s earlier research documents, worth recording precisely because this review is meant to be unbiased. (1) File 1 described 2022’s B.E.N.Z. as “AI applications deployed in smart agriculture ecosystems”; the competition’s own history page describes a GIS-based tree-placement and urban-forest project⁹ — less AI, more geography. (2) The same file listed Cartelogy as a 2019 Team of Excellence; the Open Contracting Partnership’s contemporaneous account says “top 2 teams out of almost 30 applicants”³, while a Malaysian government portal celebrates a different Malaysian team (“Mentadak”) as award-winning — the precise 2019 honor roll is thus partially ambiguous in accessible English sources, and we flag rather than resolve it. Neither correction changes the structural findings; both illustrate how easily secondary summaries drift toward the more flattering, more AI-flavored version of events.

4 Verdict: Good Project, or National Need?

The evidence supports a two-stage answer. Project quality is the entry ticket; national timing is the selector. Nothing in the record shows a weak project winning: every examined winner had a working artifact, used open data, and could demonstrate. But nothing in the record shows raw technical excellence winning *against* the year’s current either — and the one winner whose technical depth most clearly exceeded its peers (A/B Street) won in precisely the year its subject matter became the zeitgeist, three years after it was built. The rubric’s arithmetic (70% of preliminary weight on feasibility and social importance, 30% on innovation¹), the annually re-set presidential theme, and the diplomatic staging of the award all point the same way as the case record.

Put more bluntly, for the benefit of our own entry: the question “is it really a good project or just the nation’s immediate need?” assumes a dichotomy the competition does not contain. The Presidential Hackathon is a *policy showcase that uses competition mechanics*. It selects for the intersection: projects good enough to demo without embarrassment, aimed precisely at what the state most needs demonstrated that year, carried by teams whose composition serves Taiwan’s international story. Within that intersection, “better project”

still matters — the 2025 field had nine finalists¹⁴, and demonstrable maturity visibly separates winners from the invisible losing pool — but outside that intersection, quality alone has no observed path to victory.

Two honest caveats bound this verdict. First, survivorship: we cannot examine rejected entries, so “no weak project wins” is really “no weak project is visible among winners.” Second, afterlife is a lagging and noisy indicator: CropNow and Beyond Hearing are recent, and quiet teams may be active teams. The 50/50 afterlife split (Finding 3) should be read as “the competition does not guarantee sustainability,” not as “half of all winners failed.”

4.1 What this means for the CarbonPass entry

The findings translate directly into entry strategy, and they largely confirm — with one sharpened warning — the approach already taken in this project’s proposal documents:

- **Confirmed: theme-lock is non-negotiable.** No winner has beaten the year’s current. CarbonPass’s framing of the carbon-data divide as 2026’s digital-inclusion problem is the correct kind of move — provided the inclusion is visible in the demo (the LINE/voice interface), not just argued in prose (Finding 1).
- **Confirmed: bring something that already works.** Half the winners pre-existed the event; feasibility outweighs innovation in the rubric. The plan to arrive with a working data-pack engine on real bill formats, and to secure a Gangshan pilot during mentorship, mirrors what distinguishes winners (Finding 2).
- **Confirmed: the multinational team and the exportable story matter.** India’s recurrence and the ceremony’s diplomatic cast are data (Finding 4). CarbonPass’s “every SME-exporting economy faces this wall” expansion path is the right register.
- **Sharpened warning: winning is not a sustainability plan.** The afterlife record says the competition amplifies but does not sustain (Finding 3). Every winner that lasted had an institution behind it. For CarbonPass, the integration targets (MOENV’s CBAM platform, SMESA’s service network, TIFI/MIRDC) are therefore not a rhetorical flourish in the proposal — they are, on this evidence, the difference between becoming CoST Honduras and becoming Re-Fill City.

5 Limitations

This review covers the International Track’s publicly celebrated teams (two per year in official English-language reporting); some editions named additional excellent teams not consistently listed in English. Afterlife searches were conducted in English in July 2026 and may miss activity documented only in Mandarin, Thai, or Bahasa. The 2019 honor roll contains a source discrepancy we flag but cannot resolve (Section 3.5). Assessments of “technical substance” are qualitative readings of documented functionality, not code review.

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